MINOR A

Mostly league age 9 and 10 | 11" ball | 35 ft pitching | 60 ft bases

The first year the girls pitch to each other. Every girl learns to play the game the way it is played from here up.

PURPOSE PROPOSAL

Minor A is where a girl becomes a softball player. By the end of the season, every girl can throw, catch, field and hit in a game where a girl is pitching. Every team also finishes with more girls who can play pitcher and catcher than it started with.

Winning matters because the girls care about it. It never comes ahead of development or playing time.

PITCHING PHASES DISTRICT 10 RULE

The season runs in phases to help pitchers develop. In each phase, the coach steps in to pitch a little less.

START OF SEASON TO APR 13
No walks. At ball 4 the coach steps in and finishes the count. Focus: pitchers throwing strikes without fear, batters swinging.

APR 15 TO MAY 5
Walks count. The coach steps in only when the bases are loaded and the pitcher throws ball 4. Focus: pitchers working out of trouble, batters learning the strike zone.

FROM MAY 6
No coach pitch. Real softball. Focus: everything together.

WHAT LITTLE LEAGUE SAYS LITTLE LEAGUE

- Little League runs one Minor League Softball division for ages 5 to 11. Each local league splits it into levels by age and ability, such as coach pitch and player pitch. Minor A is the top BLS level of Minors, where the girls pitch.
- The Minors field: 60 ft bases and a 35 ft pitching distance.
- Pitching limit for Minors and Majors: a girl can pitch in up to 12 innings a day. One pitch counts as an inning. If she pitches in 7 or more, she rests the next day.
- A pitcher who is taken out can't come back to pitch in the same game.
- A league age 12 player can't pitch in Minors.
- Little League's regular season minimum is 6 defensive outs and 1 at-bat for every player, every game.
- Little League's stated aim is growing well-rounded kids, not building elite ballplayers.

FOCUS SKILLS PROPOSAL

1. **Pitcher.** The windmill motion: grip, stride, arm circle, follow-through. The only goal is throwing strikes.
2. **Catcher.** Getting set behind the plate, catching pitches, blocking balls in the dirt, throwing the ball back to the pitcher.
3. **Throwing and fielding (every girl).** Ready position, ground balls, an overhand throw to first, knowing where the force out is.
4. **Hitting against a girl pitching.** Stance, load, level swing, watching the ball, and knowing when to take a walk.
5. **Running the bases.** Leave when the ball reaches the batter, steal second, run through first.

BY THE END OF THE SEASON PROPOSAL

- Every girl can make a routine throw from shortstop to first.
- Every girl knows where the force out is before the pitch.
- Every girl has batted against a girl pitching, not just a coach.
- Every team has at least 3 girls who can play pitcher for a full inning.
- Every team has at least 2 girls who can play catcher for a full inning.

NOT ENOUGH, TOO MUCH PROPOSAL

NOT ENOUGH

- The same 1 or 2 girls pitch every inning of every game.
- A girl who wants to try pitcher or catcher never gets the chance.
- Practice is mostly batting practice.
- No time spent on throwing to first.
- Girls stand in the outfield all season.

TOO MUCH

- Asking a pitcher for speed before she can throw strikes.
- Fixing everything in a pitcher's motion at once. Pick one thing.
- More than 3 team practices a week.
- Coaching every pitch from the dugout during games.
- A girl pitching more innings than the rules allow.

A 90-MINUTE PRACTICE PROPOSAL

Warm up + throw 15	Stations 40	Team defense 20	Run 15

- **Stations:** pitchers and catchers working together, infield ground balls, hitting off a pitcher or a machine. Rotate every 13 minutes.
- **Team defense:** force outs, cutoffs, covering bases.
- **Running:** leaving on the pitch, stealing second, rundowns.

GAME RULES THAT CHANGE COACHING RULE

- 3 outs or 10 batters per inning, 5 runs max, including the last inning.
- Continuous batting order. Every girl plays at least 6 defensive outs.
- No new inning after 1 hour 45 minutes.
- No dropped third strike. No stealing while the coach is pitching.
- Runners leave only when the pitch reaches the batter.
- Pitching is limited by innings: 12 per day max, and 7 or more needs a day of rest.

COACH'S ROLE PROPOSAL

- Teach one thing at a time and let the girls play the game.
- Plan who plays pitcher and catcher each game, and tell each girl why she plays where she plays.
- Tell parents at the first meeting: walks and errors are part of Minor A, and the coach steps out of pitching in phases on purpose.